

Cutting

PC peripheral and component prices keep falling, and laser printers are riding the trough of the price wave. Our test features the best personal laser printers, and should help you decide on one

Sanket Naik

Not long ago, laser printers were considered the devices that would one day suck inkjet printers dry. Laser printers had their distinct advantages; speed, the ability to output smudge-free printouts, and durability. However, sky-high pricing meant that only businesses and those with deep pockets could afford them.

Over the years, both inkjet and laser technologies have evolved, and it's increasingly hard to differentiate those once-distinct advantages that lasers exhibited. Subtle differences still provide the necessary demarcation, but these are based on application areas and not on technical grounds—such as photo printers, mobile printers, etc.

Colour printing, which was once only inkjet domain, is now a much-battled segment, thanks mainly to the lower initial investment for a colour laser, and also the lower running costs.

Regardless of whether you buy a laser or an inkjet, what

you're looking for is speed, quality, and economy. However, there's a lot more to printing than these three basic requirements: the cost of the consumables is the first addition to this list. Another oft-forgotten factor is the manufacturer's service and support offerings, which are important because printers are prone to failure as a result of neglect, overuse, and ageing. This test will aim to take a more holistic, and thus more real-world look at the printing solutions on offer.

We received printers from all the top retailing brands—alphabetically: Brother, Canon, Epson, HP, Lexmark, Samsung, and Xerox. Due to some unfortunate technical problems with Epson's printer, we were unable to test it. This test covers primarily entry-level laser printers, and we'll take a look at the mid-range offerings in next month's test. However, apart from the entry-level mono lasers tested here, we also have four colour lasers tested individually.